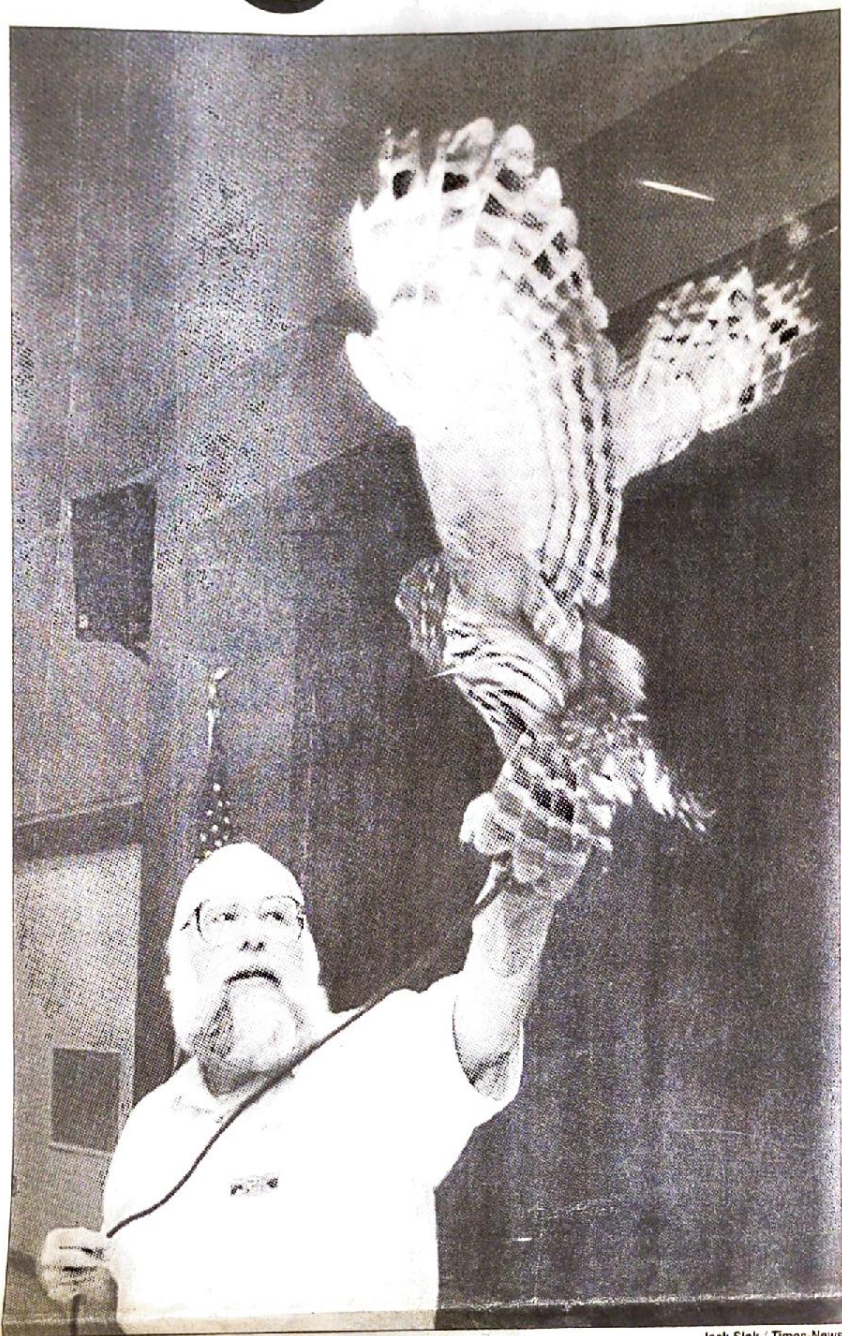




Jack Sink / Times-News

Tom Rouse of the Carolina Raptor Center of Charlotte holds an owl Friday at Smith Elementary School. Rouse and three birds of prey came to the school's Science and Technology Day.

Fifth-graders meet birds of prey

Raptor Center guests part of science day at Smith Elementary

By Lea Delicio
Times-News

Athena, Michael and Jesse Jay watched suspiciously from their perches as 70 fifth-graders filed in to Smith Elementary School's gymnasium Friday morning.

The children were asked to be quiet and not make any sudden moves to avoid spooking the threesome — a red-tailed hawk,

a great horned owl and a barred owl.

The three visited the school Friday courtesy of the Carolina Raptor Center of Charlotte as a part of Smith Elementary's Science and Technology Day.

The Raptor Center takes in birds of prey — or meat-eating birds — that are sick, injured or orphaned and nurses them back to health, said Tom Rouse of the Raptor Center.

If the birds cannot be made healthy enough to go back out into the wild — like Athena, Michael and Jesse Jay — the

Raptor Center cares for them and gives them a permanent home, Rouse told the fifth-graders.

"We become their caretakers til the day they die," he said.

Athena was shot in the wing. Michael fell out of a tree and was bitten by a dog, and Jesse Jay was hit by a car, he said.

Rouse spent the morning at Smith Elementary educating the students about birds of prey, including how they are most likely to be injured and how

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